

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 10

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A widow sorts through her late husband's wardrobe a year after his death.

1

The wardrobe had been closed for a year almost to the day. I had walked past it every morning, every evening, and on a handful of nights when I could not sleep I had stood before it with my hand on the brass knob and then taken my hand away again. Today, for no reason I could name, the door opened easily. The hinges, which I had been certain would protest, made no sound at all. Inside, his shirts hung in the order he had always kept them: white at the left, then the pale blues, then the patterned ones he wore on Sundays, and at the far right, the one good navy blazer he had bought for our daughter's graduation and worn perhaps four times in his life.

2

I had not expected the order to undo me, but it did. He had been, for forty-one years, a man of small, exact arrangements — the coffee tin always turned so its label faced the kitchen, the newspaper folded back along its original crease before it was set down. I touched the sleeve of a pale blue shirt. The cotton was thinner than I remembered. I lifted it from the rail and held it for a moment against my own shoulder, the way one might hold a child's coat against a child who is no longer the size to wear it.

3

The radio on his bedside table was, for the first time in a year, switched off. He had kept it on at a murmur every night, tuned to the World Service, because he liked, he said, to fall asleep to the sound of someone telling him news from a place he would never visit. I had left it untouched after the funeral, partly out of habit, partly because the murmur in the next room was the closest thing I had to his breathing. Two weeks ago I had finally turned the dial to off. The silence that followed was, at first, intolerable. By the third night, I had begun to sleep again.

4

I worked slowly. Each shirt was folded and laid in one of two piles — one for the charity shop on the

high street, the other, smaller, for keeping. The keeping pile was for objects I could not yet justify: a soft grey jumper I had bought him one Christmas, a tie his sister had sent from abroad. I told myself I would decide about them later. Later, I had come to understand, was a useful country to which grief allowed one occasional visits.

5

It was in the inside pocket of his old tweed coat — the one he wore to walk the dog — that I found the letter. The envelope was unstamped and unaddressed, the paper slightly furred from a year of being pressed against wool. My name was written on the front in his careful, slanting hand. I sat down on the edge of the bed because my legs would not, just then, hold me. I did not open it at once. I held it for a long time, between two fingers, the way one might hold something that could yet turn out to be a dream.

6

The letter, when I finally read it, was short and entirely characteristic. He had written it, the date told me, six weeks before the diagnosis — long before either of us had known anything was wrong. It was a list, in pencil, of small instructions: where the spare keys to the shed were taped, the name of the plumber he trusted, the password to the old computer in the study. At the very bottom, in slightly larger letters, he had added: **And, when you have finished being sensible, go and have lunch with Margaret. She has always been fond of you.** I laughed, then, for the first time in a long while, and the laugh and the tears came out together and were not, I thought, very different from each other.

7

The phone rang at four. It was our daughter, calling from her office in a city three hours away. I had been planning to tell her about the wardrobe in a careful, edited way, but the letter sat folded on my knee and I found that I could not edit anything at all. I read her the postscript. There was a silence on the line, and then she said, in a voice I had not heard since she was a small child, **Oh, Mum.** We did not say anything else for a little while. I listened to her breathing, three hours away, and I thought how strange it was that one could be comforted, across such a distance, by something so ordinary as breath.

8

That evening I closed the wardrobe again, but not all the way. I left a finger's width of light along its edge. The charity bag stood by the door, neatly tied. The keeping pile sat on the chair by the window, waiting for a decision I would, eventually, make. On the bedside table the radio remained off; but I thought, going to bed, that tomorrow I might turn it on for an hour, very low, and see what news the world had for me from a place I would never visit.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her late husband's wardrobe had been "closed for a year almost to the day." Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show she had found it difficult to open the wardrobe before now. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. The narrator did "not expect the order to undo me." Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about her reaction to seeing his shirts. [2]

3. The narrator compares holding her husband's shirt to holding "a child's coat against a child who is no longer the size to wear it." What does this comparison suggest about her feelings? [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. Why had the narrator left the radio on for so long after her husband's death? Answer in your own words. [2]

5. The narrator describes the silence after turning the radio off as “intolerable.” What does this word suggest about her state at that point? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator writes that “later... was a useful country to which grief allowed one occasional visits.” Explain what this image suggests about how she is dealing with her grief. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 5 that shows the narrator was emotionally shaken by finding the letter. [1]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator says her husband’s letter was “entirely characteristic.” Using your own words, explain **two** things about her husband’s character that the letter reveals. [2]

9. The narrator writes that her laugh and her tears “were not, I thought, very different from each other.” What does this suggest about her emotional state at this moment? [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator’s daughter says only “Oh, Mum.” Why do you think the writer chose to give the daughter such a short line of speech? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. The narrator closes the wardrobe “but not all the way,” leaving “a finger’s width of light along its edge.” What does this small detail suggest about how she has changed by the end of the passage? [2]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: An opinion article on why people sleep less than they used to.****1**

A hundred and fifty years ago, the average adult in Britain or America is thought to have slept for between eight and nine hours a night. Today, depending on whose survey one trusts, that figure has fallen to a little under seven, and among young professionals in the world's busier cities it has slipped lower still. Sleep, once treated as a daily necessity as obvious as eating, has quietly become a contested resource — fought over, postponed, and, in the language of the modern workplace, “optimised”. The shift has been gradual enough that few of us have noticed it, but its consequences are now serious enough that doctors, economists and even employers are beginning, belatedly, to pay attention.

2

The historical change began, as so many modern changes did, with the electric light bulb. Before Edison's invention spread into ordinary homes, the day for most people ended when the sun did. A candle or an oil lamp gave just enough light to finish a meal or read a few pages; it did not, in any practical sense, let one work into the small hours. The bulb changed that, and the screen — first the television, then the computer, and finally the phone — completed the change. The biological signals that once told the human brain that night had fallen are now overruled, every evening, by a small bright rectangle held a few centimetres from the eyes.

3

Light, however, is only half the story. The other half is cultural. Somewhere between the nineteen-eighties and today, a quiet revolution took place in how educated societies talk about sleep. To rise before dawn became a virtue; to sleep eight hours, a sign of softness. Tech-industry executives boasted, in interviews, of “four-hour nights”; ambitious students compared, like duellists, the dates of their last full night's rest. Sleep was recast as something one **spent**, like money, and the implication was always that the more one spent on it, the less one had left for productive things. The result is a culture in which exhaustion is, perversely, a badge of seriousness.

4

The medical evidence against this culture is, by now, overwhelming. The Centers for Disease Control in the United States has called insufficient sleep a “public health epidemic”. Adults who sleep fewer than six hours a night have, according to a large meta-analysis published in 2017, a significantly higher risk of cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, depression and early death than those who sleep seven or eight. The cognitive effects, though less dramatic, are no less troubling: a single night of four hours' sleep produces a measurable drop in reaction time comparable, the researchers note, to a blood-alcohol level above the legal driving limit. We would not permit a colleague to come to work intoxicated. We routinely permit ourselves to come to work that tired.

5

None of this is news to the sleep-deprived themselves. Surveys repeatedly show that those who sleep poorly **know** they sleep poorly, and that they would, given the chance, sleep more. The obstacle is rarely ignorance. It is, more often, structural. Shift workers cannot choose when their bodies are asked to be awake. Parents of small children, particularly mothers, sleep at the mercy of someone else's lungs. Junior professionals in finance and law are expected to answer emails that arrive at eleven at night and again at six in the morning. To tell such people to “try going to bed earlier” is, frankly, to miss the problem.

6

What, then, can be done? Some of the most effective changes are not individual but institutional. A handful of forward-thinking firms have begun to ban after-hours emails, to provide “nap rooms” for staff on long shifts, and — most radically — to treat sleep deprivation as a workplace safety issue,

alongside slips, trips and falls. Schools in several American states have, after years of lobbying by paediatricians, pushed back the start of the secondary-school day, with measurable improvements in academic performance and a small but real reduction in teen road accidents. At the individual level, the most reliable advice is unfashionably simple: keep the bedroom dark and cool, leave the phone in another room, and try, as far as one's circumstances allow, to wake and sleep at roughly the same hours each day.

7

We are perhaps at the end of the long experiment of treating sleep as a luxury. The early returns of that experiment, weighed in heart attacks and motorway crashes and quiet years of low mood, are not encouraging. A more honest accounting is beginning to emerge — one in which a full night's rest is recognised not as a guilty indulgence but as one of the cheapest, most effective forms of medicine we possess. Whether that recognition translates into a society in which people **actually** sleep more is, for the moment, an open question. The answer will depend less on what the doctors tell us than on what our employers, our schools and we ourselves choose to do when the lights go out.

From Paragraph 1

12. Give **two** facts from Paragraph 1 that show people today sleep less than they once did. [2]

13. The writer says that sleep has “quietly become a contested resource.” Explain, in your own words, what he means. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, how did the electric light bulb change the human relationship with night-time? Answer in your own words. [2]

15. The writer describes the phone as “a small bright rectangle held a few centimetres from the eyes.” What is the **effect** of describing the phone in this way? [2]

From Paragraph 3

16. Why does the writer put the phrase **four-hour nights** in inverted commas? [1]

17. The writer says that in modern culture “exhaustion is, perversely, a badge of seriousness.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about how sleep is now viewed. [2]

From Paragraph 4

18. The writer compares working tired to “a blood-alcohol level above the legal driving limit.” Why does he use this comparison? [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer says it is “to miss the problem” to tell sleep-deprived people simply to “try going to bed earlier.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that support this view. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What is the writer’s **attitude** towards firms that ban after-hours emails and treat sleep deprivation as a safety issue? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer calls a full night’s rest “one of the cheapest, most effective forms of medicine we possess.” Explain what is **effective** about describing sleep as “medicine.” [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the reasons people sleep less today** and **what employers, schools and individuals can do to address the problem**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

People today sleep less than their grandparents because ...

— END OF PAPER —